

SMART TOOLS, REMARKABLE RESULTS



SUPER PRODUCTIVE

HACKS · APPS · AI · AUTOMATION · DEEP WORK
THE COMPLETE STACK FOR KNOWLEDGE WORKERS

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Preface.....	4
Who this book is for.....	5
Why a book?.....	5
What's to come.....	5
 Tools and Leverage.....	 6
The right tool.....	7
Free vs. paid tools.....	8
Mature vs. new tools.....	9
Tools aren't just software.....	9
 1. Workflow Optimization.....	 10
Navigation Shortcuts.....	11
Bookmarks.....	12
Text Expanders.....	13
Workbooks.....	14
 2. Cognitive Offloading.....	 15
Window Snapping.....	15
Clipboard Managers.....	16
Password Managers.....	18
Bookmarking Apps.....	19
PKM Tools.....	20
Task Planners.....	21
Lessons Learned.....	22
 3. Execution Tools.....	 23
File Format Tools.....	24
File Transfer Tools.....	25
File Organization Tools.....	26
Asset Extractors.....	27
Scratchpads.....	28

4. Virtual Communication.....	29
Voice-to-Text.....	30
Real-time Messaging.....	31
Project Management Apps.....	32
Knowledge Bases.....	33
Workflow Capture Tools.....	34
Sense-Making Tools.....	35
You've Got Email.....	36
 5. Visual Communication.....	 37
Annotated Screenshot Tools.....	37
Asynchronous Recording Tools.....	38
Collaborative Visual Workspaces.....	40
Collaborative Review Tools.....	41
 6. Information Orchestration.....	 43
Google Workspace.....	44
Google Search Operators.....	45
Chrome Extensions.....	46
Google Apps Scripts.....	47
 7. Cognitive Automation.....	 48
One tool. Three Modes.....	49
When to use AI (and when not to).....	50
How to Use Generative AI.....	51
A few prompts I use everyday.....	52
How to Use Collaborative and Agentic AI.....	54
Your Move: Three Thoughts on What to do Next.....	55
1. Embrace it, Don't Fear It.....	55
2. Rethink What's Possible.....	56
3. Use the Right AI Tool for the Job.....	57

Before you go.....	58
One last note.....	59
About the author.....	60
A small request.....	60
 Appendix.....	 61
Keyboard Shortcuts for Windows.....	62
Keyboard Shortcuts for Mac.....	64
Tools Mentioned By Chapter.....	66

Preface

Hi, I'm Brendan. I'm a web strategist and writer who has spent nearly a decade helping businesses and teams turn ideas into effective digital experiences.

I'm also a longtime productivity nerd—not because I love software, but because I hate wasted motion.

I know what it's like to wrestle with clunky systems. To lose hours to inefficient processes. To feel busy but not effective.

And I've seen the flip side: the dramatic jump in output that happens when you switch to the right tool.

Over time, I realized something: most knowledge workers don't have an effort problem—they have a tooling problem.

I wrote *Super Productive* to fix that.

This book is a practical guide to choosing the right tools, using them properly, and building a stack that multiplies your effort instead of draining it.

No fluff. No productivity theater. Just leverage.

But first, a few notes on who this book is for and how to use it.

Who this book is for

This book is for people who spend most of their workday on a computer. Not just remote workers, but anyone whose job lives inside apps, docs, and tabs. Knowledge workers who aren't deeply technical but who want to level up.

I'd say the ideal reader is a motivated learner who wants to fill in the gaps and learn a handful of tools to make work easier and themselves more productive.

Why a book?

Instead of trying to memorize everything upfront, many software developers use a "just-in-time" approach to learning—they look up solutions as problems come up.

This helps them stay focused, avoid information overload, and save time.

My intent is for you to adopt a similar approach.

Read this book so you understand what's possible. Then revisit the sections that are most relevant to you. That way, you can apply the right tool for the right problem—and not waste time trying to do everything at once.

What's to come

In the chapters ahead, I'll walk you through several key categories of tools—and within each category, highlight a few specific tools worth exploring.

Every tool in this book has been pre-vetted and personally used by me, so you can trust they work and won't waste your time.

Finally, a book about saving time should respect yours, which is why each section is short and focused. No fluff—just tools you can start using immediately.

Tools and Leverage

Before we begin, a few guiding principles for choosing tools effectively.

The right tool

My dad, who's an amateur handyman, likes to say there's a right tool for the right job. When something isn't working, it's usually not because the task is too hard—it's because you're using the wrong tool.

At work, people make this mistake constantly.

They manage their to-do list out of their inbox instead of using a task manager. They rely on repetitive, manual processes when automation exists. They force-fit familiar tools into problems those tools weren't designed to solve.

Sometimes they choose the right category of tool—but settle for a mediocre version. Two project management apps can both technically work, yet one feels clunky and slow while the other is fast and intuitive. Two AI tools can both generate text—but one saves you hours, and the other leaves you rewriting everything.

The uncomfortable truth:

Effort can't compensate for bad tools.

You can work harder, put in longer hours, and care more—but if you're using the wrong tool, you'll still lose.

The right tool doesn't just remove the disadvantage.

It creates one—in your favor.

In the military, there's a concept called a force multiplier—anything that makes a unit more effective without adding more people or effort. GPS, for example, allows small teams to complete missions that once required a much larger force. Automated manufacturing lets a single worker produce what once required dozens.

More generally, a force multiplier is anything that helps you achieve more with less effort.

A hammer multiplies your strength when driving a nail. A shovel multiplies your ability to move earth. Today, well-made software and AI tools are among the most powerful force multipliers available.

They don't just save time—they change what's possible. They free up mental space, reduce decision fatigue, and let you focus on the parts of your work that matter.

When you choose the best tool in the right category, you apply leverage to your work.

And leverage beats effort—every time.

Free vs. paid tools

Many people settle for the tools their employers give them, or the ones they're already familiar with. They don't look for better options—even when their tools are slowing them down.

Sticking to what's available is cheap and frictionless. But if it hurts your output, it's a liability.

That's why I advocate paying for software—especially tools that are easy to use, do one job really well, and genuinely make your life easier—when it makes sense.

You can get by with free tools, and many are excellent. But if a paid product helps you get more done in less time—and no free alternative matches it—the investment is usually worth it.

Most of the tools in this book are free. Some are not. If they fit your use case and offer real value, I encourage you to buy them.

The time and effort saved by a premium tool often outweighs the upfront cost—especially if you use it every day.

Mature vs. new tools

Many of the tools mentioned in this book are pretty mature by today's standards. Compared to today's AI tools, they're almost quaint.

That's on purpose.

When you're trying to save time, you need reliability more than novelty. You need tools that are predictable, fast, and frictionless—tools that disappear into the background and let you focus on the work instead of the interface.

The newest, flashiest option isn't always the most efficient. Mature tools have rough edges sanded down, workflows optimized, and years of real-world testing behind them.

Cutting-edge is exciting. Proven is productive.

This book leans toward the latter—not because innovation isn't valuable, but because saving time is less about what's possible and more about what works, consistently, every day.

Tools aren't just software

Some of the tools in this book aren't tools in the way you might expect—they're not all strictly software. A few are things like keyboard shortcuts and bookmarks, which are technically tools, even if most people wouldn't call them that.

One quiet goal of this book is to expand your definition of what a tool is: anything that helps you do something faster, better, or with less friction.

Sometimes that's an app. Sometimes it's just knowing the right keys to press.

CHAPTER 1

Workflow Optimization

The theme of this chapter is speeding up repetitive tasks—because if you have to do something more than once, it pays to make it easier next time.

That’s why the time you spend learning the following shortcuts, techniques, and tools may be one of the most valuable investments in your workflow.

Navigation Shortcuts

Knowing how to navigate is underrated.

In the real world, it's how you move through a city, a crowded subway, or your first few days in a new job.

It saves time. It cuts stress. And it gets you where you need to go faster.

The same is true online.

Power users don't just open tabs and apps. They know how to switch tasks, pick up where they left off, and never miss a beat.

Task switching isn't the enemy—getting lost is.

That's why before you download any software, before you use an AI tool, or open a new app, it might help to take a moment to learn a few shortcuts—particularly those that help you navigate your computer and browser with ease.

You don't have to learn all of them at once. But the more you learn, the smoother everything becomes. You'll face less friction and have more mental energy for getting things done.

Master a dozen, and you won't just use your tools—you'll flow through them.

Keyboard shortcuts are listed in [the appendix](#).

[Download the full shortcut cheat sheet here.](#)

Bookmarks

You already know what bookmarks are—they're shortcuts to urls: websites, platforms, and tools you use again and again, saving you the trouble of searching for them every time.

I use bookmarks for everything from web apps I use daily to websites and documents I reference frequently—anything I want quick access to without digging through my history or fully typing them out.

If there's a digital document, website, or web app you use often, I recommend you bookmark it. And when your bookmarks start filling up your screen, organize them into folders—by use case, type, or task.

It's a simple habit that pays off fast: less friction, fewer distractions, and a smoother start every time you open your browser.

P.S. One underrated benefit of bookmarks is search. Start typing a bookmark's name in the address bar and your browser will surface it instantly. Pair that with the shortcut for opening a new tab in your browser (**Ctrl + T** or **Command + T**), and you can reach almost any saved page in seconds—no mouse required.

Text Expanders

Text expansion tools (also called “text expanders”) are one of the most powerful productivity apps available.

Here’s why.

A text expansion tool, like [Atext](#) or [Text Blaze](#), lets you type a short snippet—something like [@email](#), [_name](#), or [#number](#)—and instantly expand it into a full block of text, such as your email address, name, or phone number.

It saves time, reduces repetitive typing, and helps you stay consistent—whether you’re filling out forms, writing emails, or crafting code.

Where things get *really* powerful is when you start creating custom snippets tailored to your workflow and routine tasks. You can generate URLs, canned responses, or even AI prompts you reuse often.

Many tools also support dynamic fields like dates, email templates, code boilerplates, or more complex macros that adapt based on context. For example, a single shortcut could generate a personalized client response, complete with today’s date and your signature—no manual edits needed.

Once you get used to it, you’ll wonder how you ever worked without it.

P.S. Wondering how to create shortcuts you won’t accidentally type out?

Add a unique prefix—like [_](#) or [@](#)—to your trigger words. That way, snippets only expand when you mean to use them.

Workbooks

This is more of a tip than a tool, but it's been a game-changer for how I approach my work—and it's rooted in a simple principle: don't repeat yourself.

Whenever I'm assigned a task that's more involved than a quick one-off, I create a separate master document to serve as a dedicated workspace for it. Inside the doc, I gather everything I might need to complete the work: links to relevant resources, background context, reminders about things to watch out for, and any ideas or questions that come up along the way.

Instead of repeatedly hunting through chat threads, emails, browser tabs, and bookmarks every time I come back to a task, everything lives in one place. And because it's mine, I can structure it however I want—add notes to myself, highlight important details, or leave breadcrumbs that make it easier to pick the work back up later.

Once the workbook exists, I link it directly to the task in my planner. That way, when I sit down to start working, I'm not redoing setup work or retracing steps—I just click the workbook and everything I need is already there.

It's essentially a digital version of *mise en place*, the practice professional chefs use to prepare and organize everything before they start cooking. By having everything “in its place” before you begin, you eliminate setup work and can move straight into execution.

The goal isn't to be organized—it's to never have to set the same task up twice.

Cognitive Offloading

UX designers—the people largely responsible for designing the websites and apps we use every day—have a deep understanding of human behavior and how our minds work. They rely on a set of basic rules, or “heuristics,” that make interfaces feel predictable and easy to use.

One of these heuristics is recognition over recall: the idea that it’s easier to recognize information when it’s visible than to remember it from scratch.

A closely related concept is cognitive load—the amount of mental effort required to process information. The more you have to think about, the harder it is to focus and get things done. Reducing cognitive load makes it easier to navigate a site or app, find what you need, and complete tasks without feeling overwhelmed.

That’s the theme of this chapter: outsourcing memory—what psychologists sometimes call cognitive offloading. Our brains have limited capacity to store and retrieve information, so by relying on external tools to hold things for us, we free up mental space.

With less to remember, we can focus better, think more clearly, and get more done.

Window Snapping

Being able to move things around is the key to an organized house.

When everything has a place, you can easily move things where they belong or out of the way—and adapt your space to whatever you need in the moment.

“Window snapping”—shorthand for moving application windows into organized positions on your screen—works the same way.

By placing apps side by side, you spend less time switching between tasks. By putting the apps you use most in the right spots, your digital workspace starts to feel as calm and intentional as a well-organized room.

Fortunately, both Windows and Mac already have window snapping built in. On Windows, you can press and hold the Windows key and use the arrow keys to snap your active window into place—or, in Windows 11, hover over the maximize button to choose a Snap Layout. On Mac, hover over the green full-screen button to tile a window to either side, or drag windows to the edges to organize them.

If you want fully customizable keyboard shortcuts or advanced layouts, you’ll need an additional tool. On Mac, apps like [Magnet](#) (paid) or [Rectangle](#) (free) let you assign precise shortcuts and create custom window sizes. Microsoft’s free [PowerToys](#) app includes FancyZones, which offers similar features for Windows. For power users, the extra speed and flexibility are often worth it.

P.S. You might not think of window snapping as a form of outsourcing memory, but it’s a subtle example of cognitive offloading. By giving your windows fixed, visible positions, you no longer have to remember where things are—the layout does the remembering for you.

Clipboard Managers

You may already know what your clipboard is—a temporary storage area on your computer or device where data that you cut or copy is kept before you paste it somewhere else.

A clipboard manager is simply a tool that saves everything you copy, not just the last item, so you can grab it later in a couple of clicks.

Instead of relying on memory—or worse, digging through documents or reopening tabs—to find text, links, or files you’ve copied, you can easily browse a visual history and find it in seconds.

Then you can copy and paste it again, and again, and again, and again.

With everything at your fingertips, you’ll think less, work faster, and stay focused on the task at hand. You’ll feel freer and your output will show the difference.

Windows has a built-in clipboard history you can access with Win + V, but its search and organization features are limited. Mac, on the other hand, only stores the most recent copied item and doesn’t include your history.

Modern clipboard managers go much further. They can store text, links, images, and even files, while letting you quickly search your history to find exactly what you need.

For those reasons, I recommend [Pasteboard](#) (for Windows) and [Maccy](#) (for Mac), which offer all of these features. They’re also secure, lightweight, and keyboard-friendly—perfect for working without breaking your flow.

Password Managers

Remembering passwords is pure mental overhead with no upside.

Every app wants one. And picking something that's strong and easy to remember? That's just plain annoying.

That's why a good password manager is one of those tools that once you have, you can't imagine working without.

I use (and recommend) [1Password](#) or [Bitwarden](#).

They generate strong passwords, store them securely, and remove the mental clutter completely. Plus, their browser extensions autofill everything for you.

Yes, password managers cost money. Yes, you have to manage them.

But strong passwords shouldn't compete for your attention. Your brain has better things to do.

P.S. If you insist on creating your own, here's a dead-simple format:

Animal-Place-3digits-2symbols

Ask AI to make it rhyme:

Moose-Chartreuse-849!#

Duck-Bangkok-224\$%

Dog-Prague-193#&

Bee-Tbilisi-506@!

- ✓ Easy to remember.
- ✓ Hard to crack.
- ✓ Works everywhere.

Mix and match animals, places, numbers, and symbols—you'll never run out of options.

Bookmarking Apps

In the last chapter, we talked about bookmarks—saved links in your browser that help you jump back to important pages.

Bookmarking apps take that idea much further. They give you a better way to save, organize, and search through hundreds (or thousands) of links.

It's like giving your bookmarks a brain—and a filing cabinet.

Instead of a long, messy list, you can tag links, group them into folders, add notes, and sync everything across your devices. Some apps take it a step further: allowing you to annotate your links, or by showing a clean, clutter-free version of a page.

If your browser bookmarks are starting to feel like a junk drawer, a bookmarking app can turn them into a well-organized library.

If you're new to bookmarking apps, start by choosing one that fits your use case. I use different tools for different kinds of content. For example, I use [Instapaper](#) to save articles I want to read later, and [Raindrop](#) to organize websites and web apps with tags.

Other great options worth exploring include [MyMind](#) and [Readwise Reader](#).

PKM Tools

Full disclosure: I don't use PKM tools personally. My work doesn't require much research, and with intelligence increasingly available on demand through AI, most of what I might save can be resurfaced in a click. That said, for people who think for a living—writers, researchers, students, strategists—a good PKM can become one of the most valuable tools they own. That's why it's here.

Bookmarking tools help you save and organize links to apps and articles. Personal Knowledge Management (PKM) tools take it a step further.

They're designed not just to store information, but to help you think.

Instead of simply collecting links, you collect ideas. You write notes. You connect concepts. You build a web of understanding over time.

It's like turning your notes into a living map of your mind.

Tools like [Obsidian](#) and [Roam](#) let you link ideas together and see backlinks—links that show which notes reference your current note. Rather than filing information into folders, you create *relationships* between ideas.

This makes them especially powerful for research, writing, learning complex topics, managing long-term projects, and building a “second brain” (a system for organizing and connecting your ideas).

If bookmarking apps are libraries, personal knowledge tools are workshops. They're not just for storing information—they're for working with it.

P.S. PKMs require more intention than other tools in this category. You're not just saving something for later; you're deciding how it connects to what you already know.

If you're new to PKMs, start simple. Create notes as you read and link related ideas. Don't worry about building a perfect system. There are plenty of tutorials online that can teach you how to get the most out of them.

Task Planners

In 1918, productivity consultant Ivy Lee introduced a simple but powerful method for improving daily focus and effectiveness—one that’s just as relevant today as it was over a century ago.

The idea is simple: at the end of each workday, write down the six most important tasks you need to complete the next day. Rank them by priority, then work through them one at a time, starting with the most important.

It’s more than a productivity trick—it’s a decision-making framework. By deciding in advance what matters most, you eliminate the need to constantly re-prioritize throughout the day, reducing cognitive load and making focused work easier.

It’s a timeless framework for getting more done—and it works with any kind of calendar, even a paper one.

The problem is, most modern calendar apps (and project management tools) aren’t designed for this kind of workflow. They’re overloaded with features, constant notifications, and cluttered interfaces that make it harder—not easier—to prioritize tasks.

What we have are bloated tools. What we need is a minimal planner.

That’s why I recommend using a simple weekly task planner like [Tweek](#) alongside your regular calendar app, strictly for tracking to-dos.

Each workday, I add any new tasks and scheduled meetings, attaching supporting docs (like workbooks) where needed. Then I prioritize everything on my list, including tasks carried over from the previous day (which Tweek handles automatically). From there, I simply work down the list, checking off each task as I complete it.

As productivity systems go, it’s one of the simplest—and arguably most effective—because it keeps you focused, organized, and consistently on track.

Lessons Learned

This one is simple—but useful enough that it’s worth including.

If Workbooks are where I organize everything needed to complete a task, Lessons Learned is where I capture what that task—or any experience—taught me afterward.

It’s a simple plain-text document—not for storing information, but for capturing insight.

It answers one simple question:

What did this experience teach me?

After solving a problem, making a mistake (and learning from it), or trying something new and seeing it work, I open my bookmarked Lessons Learned document and write down what I learned and what I want to remember.

That’s it. There’s no template to fill out, no system to maintain. Just a running list of things worth remembering—written in the moment, when the insight is sharpest.

It’s simple, but incredibly powerful.

Because memory is unreliable. Context fades. Details blur. What feels obvious today won’t feel obvious three months from now.

Most people learn from experience. Fewer actually keep what they learn.

Writing it down turns a fleeting realization into a permanent upgrade—a lesson you won’t have to teach yourself twice.

CHAPTER 3

Execution Tools

So far, we've covered how to avoid repeating work—and how to stop keeping everything in your head.

But there's another layer of modern productivity that's more mechanical.

It's the simple act of handling digital material.

Every day you use and manipulate text, images, files, and links. Usually, none of these tasks are difficult. But when they don't cooperate, everything feels harder than it should.

A file won't open.

An upload fails.

A document disappears.

You can't extract text from an image.

You don't have anywhere quick to put things.

Small problems. Constant friction.

That's the theme of this chapter: removing friction from the mechanics of digital work.

Execution tools don't help you think or plan. They make the work itself smoother—so your attention stays where it belongs.

File Format Tools

Formats are invisible—until they're a problem.

Most days, files just open, play, and upload. And then one day they don't. An image your system won't accept. A locked PDF. A video too large to email. An audio file that won't play. The content is fine—the format isn't.

That's where file format tools come in. They're not creative suites; they're practical utilities that make files compatible, lighter, or editable without starting over.

A few places this shows up:

When compatibility gets in the way

Sometimes you just need one format instead of another. A JPG instead of a PNG. An MP3 instead of a WAV. Tools like [FreeConvert](#) and [CloudConvert](#) make the switch simple.

When documents, like PDFs, need to move

[Smallpdf](#) converts PDFs to Word (and a half-dozen other formats), compresses large PDFs, merges PDFs, or adds signatures in minutes.

When media needs adjusting

[123apps](#) handles the everyday fixes: convert video formats, resize video, trim audio, extract sound.

When size is the problem

Sometimes the file works perfectly. It's just too large. Tools like [TinyPNG](#) shrink images dramatically without noticeable quality loss. Many of the tools above include compression features, too.

Format tools make your files work wherever they need to.

They reduce friction. They keep your workflow moving. And they prevent small issues from becoming delays.

File Transfer Tools

Most files are small—until they aren't.

A quick document can travel by email without a thought. But large documents, design files, videos, or folders full of images quickly hit size limits. Attachments fail. Uploads stall. Links expire. And suddenly, sending one file becomes a fifteen-minute problem.

Sometimes compression helps. Sometimes you don't want to reduce quality—or the file is already as small as it can be.

File transfer tools exist for this reason. They move large files from one place to another without friction.

They don't store your life.

They don't organize your system.

They simply deliver.

If you want a reliable and secure option that handles almost everything, [SwissTransfer](#) is hard to beat.

It lets you send files up to 50 GB without an account, keep links active for up to 30 days, and make up to 500 transfers per day.

Transfers are encrypted, and you can add password protection or control download limits when needed.

No ecosystem. No subscriptions. No unnecessary complexity.

Just upload, generate a link, and send.

When a file needs to move, it just works.

File Organization Tools

The longer you use a computer, the more small decisions you accumulate.

Where should this go? What should I name it? Will I find it later?

Individually, these decisions seem small. Repeated daily, they create background noise—and background noise slows execution.

File organization tools replace memory with structure. Instead of improvising, you use patterns. Instead of piles, you use systems.

A few examples:

Bulk Renaming Tools

[WebRename](#) lets you rename large batches of files using clear, consistent patterns.

Automated File Sorting Tools

[File Juggler](#) (for Windows) or [Hazel](#) (for Mac) automatically move and rename files based on rules you set.

File Search Tools

[Listary](#) (for Windows) and [Alfred](#) (for Mac) dramatically speed up finding files, so you're never digging through folders.

The benefit isn't aesthetic. It's cognitive.

When your files are organized, retrieval becomes instant. Projects feel contained instead of scattered. And you spend less time searching.

Organization doesn't just keep things tidy. It preserves momentum.

P.S. If you stick to clear naming conventions, use folders generously, and keep your files organized in ways that reflect how you work, you may not need these specialized tools. But if clutter creeps in—or you're regularly wasting time searching—trying one or two of the tools above might be worth it.

Asset Extractors

Many jobs require gathering text, images, and links from different sources every day.

Copying a single paragraph or downloading an image is easy. The trouble starts when you need to collect many things—or pull content from unfamiliar or poorly structured sources.

What if the text you need is embedded in an image?

What if there are a dozen images you want to grab from a single page?

What if you need the actual URLs behind a group of links?

Doing all of that manually is tedious, error-prone, and a great way to drain your focus.

That's where a collection of tools I call asset extractors can help.

These are apps designed to pull raw materials—text, images, and links—out of the web quickly and cleanly, so you can spend less time copying, clicking, and cleaning things up, and more time staying focused on the work you're actually trying to do.

A few examples:

OCR tools, like [Copyfish](#) or [TextSniper](#) (for Mac), extract text from images.

Bulk image downloaders, like [Imageye](#) or [Image Extractor](#), let you grab multiple images from a page at once.

Link extractors, like [Link Grabber](#), pull the URLs behind hyperlinks so you can collect them all at once instead of opening each one manually.

Together, these tools make collecting text, images, and links faster, easier, and far less frustrating—turning a tedious task into a seamless part of your workflow.

Scratchpads

Alongside gathering text, links, and media is actually working with them—manipulating and moving them to meet your needs.

Usually, having a dedicated document for the task at hand (like a workbook or project file) is enough. But sometimes—especially for one-off tasks or something urgent—you don’t want to interrupt your flow by creating, naming, and organizing a new file. You just need a place to quickly drop things, think, and move on.

That’s where Scratchpads come in.

Since you’ll often need to work with text (in a doc or spreadsheet) or visuals (on a canvas), it helps to have ready-made spaces where you can quickly jot things down, organize ideas, and move things around—without breaking your main workflow.

I keep a bookmark folder in my browser labeled “Scratchpads,” filled with blank starting points: a blank Google Doc, a blank Google Sheet, a blank Figma file, and a few other templates I use regularly. Each one is always a click away.

The trick is simple: use them when you need them, clear them when you’re done, and leave them ready for next time.

CHAPTER 4

Virtual Communication

Communication, communication, communication.

You know the drill. It's the stuff teams, projects, and entire orgs are made of.

Of course, communication isn't just about speaking—or even listening. It's about writing with clarity, and understanding what you're reading. And when that communication happens online, things get even more interesting.

Without shared physical space or visual cues, small gaps in clarity can quickly turn into big misunderstandings.

The focus of this chapter is on virtual communication, and the tools we can use to communicate clearly across screens. Because whether you're sending an email, drafting a message in chat, or leaving a note on a shared doc, clear communication is what keeps work moving forward and everyone's sanity—your teammates', your clients', and your own—in check.

Voice-to-Text

As of this writing, there are two ways to get information out of your head and onto your screen. You can type it out, as most people do, or you can say it aloud.

While many people are better at one or the other, most default to typing simply because that's how it's always done. Now that transcription has gotten so darn good, the default is worth questioning. You can speak naturally, think in full sentences, and instantly watch your ideas appear on screen.

Tools like [SuperWhisper](#), [Flow](#), and [AudioPen](#) make this possible by converting spoken words into clean, readable text in real time. This means less friction when capturing ideas, fewer half-written notes, and a much faster path from thought to something you can actually share.

Voice-to-text tools won't replace writing—but they're incredibly effective at getting ideas out of your head quickly, before they disappear. And in a world where clear communication matters, that speed can make all the difference.

Pro tip: I use AudioPen whenever a thought feels too messy or complex to write out. It's web-based, so I can use it on my work computer, and it captures up to 3 minutes of rambling for free (or up to 15 minutes on the paid plan).

If I want the result to sound more like me, I'll copy the raw transcript and paste it into ChatGPT, then type, "Make this clear, but keep my voice." It turns my sketch of an idea into something coherent and ready to share, in seconds.

Real-time Messaging

This one's a given—but it's still worth calling out.

If you're on a team that works even semi-autonomously, you need a fast way to ask questions, unblock progress, and coordinate in the moment. That's where real-time messaging tools like [Slack](#) or [Teams](#) come in.

They're great for quick clarifications, lightweight updates, and the occasional “are you seeing this too?” moment. Used well, they keep work moving without turning every question into a meeting.

The key is using them for what they're good at: speed, not permanence.

When everything lives in chat, nothing sticks. Important decisions get buried, context disappears, and new teammates are left scrolling endlessly for answers. That's why chat alone isn't enough—you still need a project management tool to track work, capture decisions, and provide a durable source of truth.

When you combine the two, you get both speed and structure. Chat moves things forward in the moment. Your project tool makes it stick.

P.S. Real-time messaging only works if it doesn't constantly hijack your attention. So turn off non-essential notifications and check chat *intentionally* instead of reacting to every ping. Studies show it can take as much as twenty minutes to regain focus after an interruption—so protect your attention like the limited resource it is.

Project Management Apps

You might not think of project management as a form of virtual communication, but I assure you, it is. Every task, deadline, comment, and status update is a message about what matters, what's blocked, and what needs attention.

When done well, a project management tool creates shared understanding without constant meetings or check-ins. It shows teammates who's responsible for what, how work is progressing, and where things might be getting stuck. When done poorly, it becomes noise—outdated tasks, unclear ownership, and endless fields that no one wants to fill.

The trick, I think, is to use a tool that helps rather than hinders your progress. Tools loaded with unnecessary features and bloat can be overwhelming, pulling focus away from the actual work. The right tool fades into the background, supports clear communication, and lets the team focus on doing the work, not tracking it.

As far as PM tools go, I like [Asana](#), [Trello](#), and [Airtable](#). I've found others in this space—[ClickUp](#), [Jira](#) and [Wrike](#), for example—to be a bit bloated and heavy.

Your mileage, of course, may vary.

Knowledge Bases

Documentation gets a bad rap.

It sounds slow, formal, and time-consuming—something you promise to do later and rarely circle back to. But a shared knowledge base isn't about writing perfect docs. It's about not answering the same questions over and over again.

Tools like [Notion](#), [Mintlify](#) and [Slab](#) make it easy to capture what you know. A short page explaining a process. A checklist for a recurring task. A video that walks you through a workflow, once so you don't have to explain it again.

This becomes especially valuable when onboarding new teammates. Instead of throwing people into the deep end or making time to shadow someone else's work, you can point them to a clear, living source of truth. They can move at their own pace and revisit things when they need to.

Beyond onboarding, shared knowledge bases are useful for documenting internal processes, decision rationale, FAQs, project handoffs, and the “how we do things around here” details that usually live in people's heads—or get lost in chat threads.

If you work with other people, a shared knowledge base isn't bureaucracy. It's memory plus clarity. The kind of infrastructure that keeps teams aligned, efficient, and less dependent on who happens to be online.

Pro-tip: One of the most beneficial habits I've picked up is creating my own documentation system when my team doesn't have one. I spin up separate docs for specific workflows, written as simple step-by-step guides I can reference later. It saves me time, reduces mistakes, and makes it easier to jump back into tasks after time away.

It's also helpful for teammates covering for me, or running the process for the first time—so no one has to rely on memory or guesswork.

Workflow Capture Tools

It's worth mentioning that there are now plenty of tools designed to make capturing workflows—the stuff you might want to include in documentation—nearly effortless.

[Loom](#) (my personal favorite) lets you quickly record your screen and talk through a process once, instead of explaining it over and over again. This is great for documentation and explaining workflows or complex tasks, especially when nuance or context would get lost in a written message.

Tools like [Scribe](#) take this a step further by automatically turning a screen-recorded workflow into a step-by-step guide, without the need to manually capture screenshots or write instructions.

And [Guidde](#), a free browser extension, fits neatly into this category as well, letting you create simple, visual walkthroughs as you work.

Together, these tools lower the bar for documentation—making it easier to capture how work gets done, and share it with others when they need it.

Sense-Making Tools

I mentioned earlier that communication isn't just about speaking and listening. It's also about understanding—making sense of what's said.

When it comes to knowledge work, that's often the hardest part. Teams generate a constant stream of docs, chats, notes, tickets, and emails. Even when everything is clear, the volume alone makes it hard to know what matters, what was decided, and what to do next.

This is where sense-making tools come in—tools designed to help you distill information, surface key decisions, and turn scattered inputs into clear next steps.

Today, the most powerful of these are AI language models like [ChatGPT](#) and [Claude](#). Used well, an AI language model can act like a second brain for virtual communication. You can paste in a long document, meeting transcript, or chat thread and ask simple questions like: What are the key points? What decisions were made? What should happen next? Instead of rereading everything, you get clarity in seconds.

Some modern tools are even purpose-built around specific sense-making use-cases. [Otter](#), for example, is designed for team meetings. Record a conversation with the app and it'll generate a transcript, highlight key moments, and surface action items so decisions don't get lost once the meeting ends.

[NotebookLM](#) takes a different approach. It's built to help you understand information from documents and other sources you might normally have to read. Instead of skimming tabs or re-reading notes, you can ask questions and get clear, grounded answers based on the material you've provided.

The value here isn't automation—it's reduced cognitive load. Sense-making tools help turn raw information into understanding, and understanding into action, so communication doesn't just happen—it actually lands.

You've Got Email

Email. Everyone has it. Everyone gets it.

Unlike real-time messaging and project management apps—arguably optional productivity tools—email is essential. That's why it deserves discussion.

That doesn't mean it's the most efficient form of online communication. But because it's so ubiquitous, it remains a foundational tool in professional life.

So here's my two-cent take: email only works as an effective communication tool if you actually read what people send you. Otherwise, it's just a glorified spam folder.

That's why keeping your inbox clear matters. When it's organized, you see what's new the moment it arrives.

Yes, maintaining it is a constant chore. But it's a worthwhile one—it enables prompt responses and prevents overlooked tasks from becoming problems later.

What many people do instead—letting messages accumulate and ignoring incoming messages—ironically makes everything harder.

Important updates get buried. Follow-ups slip through the cracks. “Checking email” becomes a looming task rather than a quick routine check-in.

My advice? Flag anything that requires action today. Move items you'll need within the month into a dedicated folder for later review. Archive everything else—you can always retrieve it later with a search.

Keep your inbox clean. Check it a few times a day.
It beats getting lost in the clutter.

Visual Communication

If you work on the web you've definitely had to explain what's on your screen to someone else. Of course, whether you're pointing out a bug, giving design feedback, or walking someone through a workflow, clearly communicating what you're seeing isn't always as simple as it should be.

That's where visual communication—the art of capturing, clarifying, and sharing what you see—comes in handy.

In this chapter, you'll learn how to do just that in a way that's clear, efficient, and engaging. The tools we'll cover will help you quickly capture information, highlight what matters, and share it without unnecessary back-and-forth.

Annotated Screenshot Tools

If you're a knowledge worker, a fast and reliable screenshot tool isn't optional—it's essential.

The right tool lets you make your point in seconds. The wrong one has you wasting time fiddling with crops, edits, and workarounds.

Most operating systems include basic screenshot features, but they often fall short. Clunky interfaces, limited editing options, and awkward workflows can turn a simple task into a frustrating one.

A great screenshot tool, in contrast, should let you:

- **Capture flexibly**—grab your full screen, a selected area, or even long, scrolling pages with a keystroke (for example, Ctrl + Shift + 3).
- **Annotate efficiently**—add highlights, arrows, text, or shapes to clarify exactly what you mean.
- **Edit on the spot**—crop, resize, or blur sensitive information without switching apps.
- **Organize and save**—store screenshots locally or in the cloud so they're easy to find later.
- **Share seamlessly**—generate links you can send via email, chat, or other collaboration tools.

I recommend [Jumpshare](#) (for Windows) and [CleanShot](#) (for Mac). Both offer all of the features above, are relatively affordable, and make capturing, editing, and sharing screenshots effortless—so you can focus on your work instead of fighting your tools.

P.S. Screenshots are an excellent way to show what you're seeing to a human, but they're also incredibly helpful when using AI tools because they provide real context instead of a written description. Plus, most AI tools make it effortless—just copy the image (Ctrl + C) and paste it (Ctrl + V) into the chat.

Asynchronous Recording Tools

Sometimes, a screenshot doesn't quite cut it.

For example, when you're trying to explain a workflow, walk through a process, or show how something actually works step by step.

That's where asynchronous recording tools like [Loom](#) come in handy.

Instead of writing long explanations or hopping on yet another meeting, you can record your screen (and optionally your camera and voice) and explain things once—clearly and visually. People can watch it on their own time, rewind if needed, and come back to it later.

Tools like Loom make this effortless. You hit record, talk through the process, send the link, and move on.

It's a simple way to reduce meetings, speed up communication, and make sure your message actually lands.

Collaborative Visual Workspaces

Most knowledge work starts out messy.

You're juggling ideas, screenshots, notes, edge cases, and half-formed strategies—but the tools you use (docs, slides, spreadsheets) force everything into rigid, linear formats.

So you spend more time formatting than thinking.

The problem isn't your ideas.

It's the canvas.

Collaborative visual workspaces like [Figma](#), [Miro](#), and [tldraw](#) can solve this.

At their core, these tools offer an infinite, frictionless drag-and-drop workspace.

Instead of squeezing ideas into pages, you can:

- **Map ideas spatially**—strategies, workflows, org charts, research themes.
- **Reorganize instantly**—drag concepts around as your thinking evolves.
- **Drop in real context**—paste screenshots, charts, and references directly onto the canvas.
- **Annotate clearly**—arrows, highlights, comments, and labels remove ambiguity.
- **Show and tell visually**—share concepts in a way others can grasp at a glance.
- **Collaborate asynchronously**—comment directly on the work, not in threads.

The result isn't prettier documents. It's clearer thinking.

When ideas are visible and spatial, they're easier to refine—and much easier for others to understand.

Collaborative Review Tools

Creating work is one thing. Reviewing it is where things usually fall apart.

Feedback gets scattered across emails, chat messages, and half-remembered calls. Comments are vague, duplicated, or lost entirely.

Collaborative review tools fix that.

They centralize feedback and tie it directly to the work. Instead of “On slide 14... I think?” you get precise, contextual comments. Instead of messy version debates, you get a single source of truth. Instead of chasing approvals, you see what’s done and what’s pending.

Good review tools don’t just collect comments. They structure the conversation, make feedback actionable, and create accountability.

The key is using the right tool for the right task. Writing reviews belong in a doc. Website and design feedback works best when comments live directly on the page. When feedback stays in context, reviews move faster and issues get fixed correctly.

With that in mind, here are my favorite review tools, grouped by use case:

For documents & spreadsheets

[Google Docs](#) and [Sheets](#) are my go-to for reviewing written content, reports, and anything data-heavy. Comments live exactly where the issue is.

Suggestions can be accepted or rejected with a click. You can tag teammates, resolve threads, and track changes without creating a mess of new versions.

It’s simple, familiar, and does the job really well—especially when clarity and speed matter more than fancy features.

For websites & web pages

[Marker.io](#) and [Markup.io](#) bring that same in-context clarity to web pages and live URLs. Reviewers can click on a specific element and leave feedback directly on the page. That means no detached screenshots, no vague references, and no “top right-ish” confusion.

For design files

There’s a reason nearly every top-tier web agency uses [Figma](#): it makes it easy to comment directly on frames, components, and prototypes. And designers, developers, and stakeholders can review the same file together without exporting endless versions.

For async video feedback

[Loom](#) allows timestamped comments on videos and walkthroughs, perfect for product demos, training materials, and creative work.

The common thread? Context.

The best review tools don’t just collect opinions—they anchor feedback exactly where it belongs. And when feedback lives next to the work, collaboration stops feeling chaotic and starts feeling clear.

Information Orchestration

Search is changing. More people are turning to AI to answer their questions than ever before. Traditional search—built on keyword matching and hyperlinks—is being overshadowed by conversational AI that delivers instant, context-aware, and personalized answers.

But search was never really Google's most powerful feature. It's just the front door.

Beyond it lies the most tightly integrated suite of productivity tools ever conceived—designed not just for retrieval, but for information orchestration: capturing, organizing, transforming, and moving knowledge. It's something AI alone can't fully replace—and that most other platforms struggle to compete with.

It's hard to talk about modern productivity without acknowledging the power of this type of ecosystem. So whether you live in Docs and Sheets or approach anything made by Google with some skepticism, here's why it's worth embracing—along with a few lesser-known Google tools worth exploring.

Google Workspace

I think every team that works online should use [Google Workspace](#): Google's suite of collaboration tools built for working in real time.

In fact, even if your team relies on Microsoft products (or a different toolset entirely), I think you should, at the very least, [set up a Google account](#) and use [Chrome](#) on your own.

Here's why.

Google Workspace is built for how most teams actually work today: collaboratively, asynchronously, and in real time. Docs, Sheets, Calendar, and Drive assume shared ownership by default, which removes much of the friction around versioning, permissions, and “who has the latest file.” You can share it once and trust that everyone is working with the same copy.

Second, a large portion of today's web is built around Google's ecosystem. Having a Google account simplifies logins, integrations, extensions, and search—small conveniences that add up.

Finally, Google hires great designers, and it shows. Their products tend to be intuitive, fast, and hard to misuse, which lowers the learning curve and reduces the cognitive load of everyday work—especially for teams that don't want to spend time training people on their tools.

Even if your team uses other tools, having a Google account for work is still worth it. You can use it to sign up for tools without using your personal email, create documents that are strictly your own (and that you can take with you when you leave), and build lightweight internal tools with Apps Script (more on that below) to automate small but meaningful parts of your workflow.

Google Search Operators

I don't need to tell you about the magic of Google search, so I won't waste your time doing so.

What's less obvious is the set of controls built directly into it: Google Search Operators—special commands you can type into the search bar to refine, filter, and control your results with precision.

You can think of them as a way of speaking Google's native language. Instead of throwing a handful of keywords at the search bar and hoping for the best, operators let you be explicit about what you're looking for. For example, you can:

Lock in exact phrases using quotes, "like this"

Exclude terms with a minus sign, -word

Search within a single site using site:example.com

Find specific file types with filetype:pdf

Individually, these are simple tools. What makes them powerful is how they change your relationship to search. Rather than browsing and filtering after the fact, you're directing the query upfront—telling Google what matters and what doesn't before it ever shows you a result.

Once you start using search operators regularly, Google begins to feel less like a search engine and more like a query interface. You're no longer just "searching the web"; you're interrogating it—treating it like what it really is: a massive, continuously updated database of information.

You don't need to memorize dozens of operators to get value out of this. Mastering just a few can dramatically reduce the time you spend scrolling, refining, and re-searching, and help you get to useful sources faster with far less friction.

P.S. For a full list of Google Search Operators—and examples of how to use them—check out [this excellent guide](#) from the team at Ahrefs.

Chrome Extensions

Like Google Search, I don't need to sell you on Google Chrome. Unless you're loyal to another browser (Firefox, DuckDuckGo, Arc), you probably already use it constantly.

What you may not fully appreciate is how Chrome Extensions can quietly turn your browser into a purpose-built operating system for your work.

While Chrome itself is powerful, extensions are what make it personal. They layer your workflow directly into the web—automating the clicks you repeat, surfacing the info you constantly hunt for, and removing the friction you've just learned to tolerate.

Their brilliance lies in the fact that the developers who build them are people who might have had your exact job, or who once once shared your frustration and decided to fix it. They're not abstract software features imagined in a boardroom. They're often practical solutions to very specific, very real workflow pain*.

In that sense, the [Chrome Web Store](#) is a lot like the iOS App Store. Its community of independent builders can transform your browser from something passive into something active—shaped around your job or use case.

If you can find a few extensions for the tasks you do every day, you can offload repetitive work and let your browser do the heavy lifting, which can dramatically change how fast—and how intentionally—you move through your day.

***Case in point:** Chrome DevTools is great if you're deep in debugging. But if you just need to quickly assess the size of a component, inspect an image, or grab a hex code, it can feel like overkill. That's where [Screen Ruler](#)—one of my favorite Chrome Extensions—comes in handy. Built for web designers and developers, it lets you measure on-screen elements, spot layout issues, and pull images, fonts, and hex codes in seconds. No digging. No friction.

Google Apps Scripts

If Chrome extensions upgrade how you work, Google Apps Script upgrades what your tools can do.

For those who don't know: [Apps Script](#) is Google's built-in automation layer—a lightweight, JavaScript-based platform that connects and customizes Docs, Sheets, Gmail, Calendar, Drive, and more. It's always been powerful, but historically it came with a catch: you needed to know how to code.

Today, that barrier is basically gone.

With ChatGPT and Claude, you now can describe what you want in plain language and let AI generate, refine, and explain the script for you. You can even have it walk you through the setup step by step. Where Apps Script becomes the execution engine; AI becomes the translator between your intent and working automation.

If you already use Google Workspace, this opens the door to building small, purpose-built workflows using the tools and content you already have—cleaning messy docs, organizing spreadsheets, moving files automatically, or turning repetitive work into a one-click action.

You don't even have to know what to automate upfront. You can ask an LLM to look at your role, your tools, and your pain points—and suggest scripts that would save you time or reduce friction.

Combine AI with Apps Script, and what used to be a niche power-user feature becomes genuinely approachable—turning ideas into automations that streamline and scale the way you already work.

P.S. As of this writing, I've used Google Apps Script to save my team 30+ hours this year alone by automating tasks we used to handle manually—pulling image URLs, converting front-end links to AEM paths, extracting structured web content, flagging broken links, and converting rich text docs to HTML.

Cognitive Automation

A guide to modern productivity wouldn't be complete without mentioning AI. But rather than defining it by the technology that powers it, I think it's more useful to think about the broader category it belongs to: *cognitive automation*—a new class of software that can think for you, think with you, and increasingly act on your behalf.

Given how quickly these tools are evolving, I also think it makes more sense to focus on the modes in which we might use them, rather than anchoring ourselves to any specific platform, model, or product.

With that in mind, I'll start by sharing a mental model I've found useful for deciding what type of tool to use (there are several), followed by a few guidelines for getting the most out of each. By the end, you'll have a clearer sense of how to apply these tools in your own workflow.

One tool. Three Modes.

I like to think of AI as a single system that operates in three distinct modes: generate, assist, and act.

You’ve no doubt encountered the first. As the name implies, generative AI tools like [ChatGPT](#), [Claude](#), [Midjourney](#), and [Sora](#) produce raw material. This is where prompting matters. Small changes in what you put in can significantly impact what you get out—and the more context you give, the better. Used well, these tools reduce blank-page friction and expand your creative output.

The second mode is assist—where AI becomes a collaborator, and the output you produce together is often greater than what you’d create alone. Products like [Cursor](#), an AI-native IDE, are a clear example. But even traditional generative tools are moving in this direction, adding features like live editing, shared workspaces, and deeper context awareness.

The third mode is the newest—and potentially the most disruptive: the ability to act on your behalf. In this mode, AI doesn’t just generate or assist. *It does*. Agentic systems can handle everything from research and planning to execution and reporting. In many cases, they can complete entire workflows end to end.

Your role shifts from doing the work to orchestrating it: breaking problems into automatable chunks, designing tasks for machines, and thinking like a manager.

Agentic tools are still in their infancy, but early examples already show promise. Tools like [Manus](#) and [Gumloop](#) hint at how dramatically the nature of work may change. Instead of prompting step by step, you define the goal—and the system independently handles the research, synthesis, and production required to deliver it.

My point isn’t to chase every tool—it’s to understand the mode you’re operating in. Most people are still using these tools to generate, when the real leverage comes from learning to assist—and eventually, to delegate.

When to use AI (and when not to)

Humans have been relying on computers for a long time. We don't usually think twice about the systems that run air traffic control or traffic lights, the algorithms that shape what we see on social media, or even the technology behind our phones.

But now that AI has gone mainstream, we're faced with a new set of questions: which tools can we trust, and when should we use them?

Here's my take: AI is excellent at processing large amounts of information, identifying patterns, and generating surprisingly good first drafts, but it isn't perfect. It works best when the task is recoverable—meaning that if it makes a mistake, the cost is low—or when the output can be easily checked.

That's why I ask myself three questions whenever I decide to use it:

Is the output easy to check?

Is the cost of a mistake low?

Is this a task with a right answer?

If the answer is yes, AI is usually a good fit. If the answer is no—if the stakes are high and the output is hard to verify, I use AI to inform my thinking, not replace it.

The goal isn't to hand everything over. It's to delegate intelligently.

How to Use Generative AI

You probably don't need an introduction to generative AI's many use cases. But if you're still figuring out how to get better results from it, a few simple guidelines can make a big difference.

Most people treat AI like a search engine—type a few words and hope for the best. That works sometimes. But the quality of what you get out is almost always a direct reflection of what you put in.

A prompt is just an instruction. A good prompt is an instruction with context. Think of it like briefing a new hire. The more they understand about the task, the goal, and the audience, the better their output will be. AI works the same way. Vague instructions produce vague results. Specific instructions produce useful ones.

With that in mind, here are a few principles worth internalizing:

Give it a role. Tell the AI who it's supposed to be before you ask it to do something. "You are an experienced copywriter" or "Act as a project manager reviewing this plan" primes the model to respond from the right frame of reference.

Add context. Don't just describe the task—describe the situation. Who is this for? What does success look like? What should it avoid? The more relevant detail you include, the less guessing it has to do.

Specify the format. If you want bullet points, ask for it. If you want a short paragraph, say so. If you want it to sound like you, paste in a sample of your writing and say "keep my voice." AI will default to a generic format unless you tell it otherwise.

Iterate, don't restart. Your first prompt doesn't need to be perfect. Get something on the page, then refine it. "Make this more concise" or "rewrite the second paragraph to sound less formal" is a perfectly valid follow-up. Think of it as a conversation, not a one-shot transaction.

A few prompts I use everyday

In practice, I don't follow the guidelines above to the letter every time. I usually start with something quick and barebones and only add structure if the output misses the mark. It's faster to get something on the page and refine from there.

Over time, you build a feel for when a one-liner is enough and when you need to be more explicit. The short prompts get me 80% of the way there. When the output really matters—or the first pass misses—I switch to something more structured.

Here are a few prompts (both short and long) I use almost every day:

Make this clear (but keep my voice)

You are an experienced editor.

Rewrite the text below to improve clarity and flow while preserving my tone and voice.

Keep the meaning exactly the same.

Make it concise, remove unnecessary words, and avoid sounding overly formal.

Return the revised version only.

[paste text]

Explain this in plain language

You are a teacher explaining concepts to a beginner.

Explain the following in simple, plain language.

Avoid jargon, and use examples or analogies if helpful.

Keep it under [X] sentences and make it easy to understand on a first read.

[paste topic/text]

Turn this into a polished draft

You are a skilled communicator.

Turn the content below into a clear, well-structured draft.

Adapt it for the intended format (e.g., email, message, LinkedIn post, etc.).

Improve clarity, flow, and tone while keeping my voice and intent.

Fill in small gaps if needed, but don't add new ideas.

Keep it concise and natural, not overly formal. Return the final draft only.

[paste rough notes / transcript / ideas]

I'm stuck. What should I do?

You are a strategic advisor.

Based on the situation below, help me decide what to do next.

First, briefly summarize the situation to confirm understanding.

Then, outline 2–3 realistic options with pros and cons.

Finally, recommend one option and explain why it's the best choice.

[describe situation]

Write a meta-prompt for this task

You are an expert prompt engineer.

Help me write a high-quality prompt for the following task.

Ask clarifying questions if needed.

Then create a clear, reusable prompt with: role, context, task, and format.

[describe task]

P.S. Having a text expansion tool, like [aText](#) (mentioned in Chapter 1), makes saving and reusing these longer prompts effortless—which removes most of the excuse not to use them. All I have to do is write them once, save them, and type a quick shortcut to drop them in.

How to Use Collaborative and Agentic AI

Using tools like Claude, Cursor, or Manus to create documents, apps, or workflows can be powerful—but also highly context-dependent. Best practices are still evolving, and effective workflows vary by tool, project, and user.

That said, a few principles hold up well across most tools and use cases:

Start with a clear objective. Just like with generative AI, these tools work best when the goal is well defined. Instead of asking them to “help with a project,” describe the outcome you want—a working prototype, a research brief, a documented workflow, or a completed draft. The clearer the end state, the more useful the system becomes.

Break the work into stages. Even if a tool claims it can handle everything at once, it usually performs better when the work is divided into steps: planning, drafting, reviewing, and refining. Treat the AI like a collaborator moving through phases, rather than a system producing a finished result in one pass.

Stay in the loop. These tools can move quickly, but they still benefit from human judgment. Review intermediate outputs, guide direction, and correct assumptions early. Small course corrections along the way can prevent larger issues later.

Save your work. AI tools can be unpredictable. They can lose context, change direction, or break during longer tasks. Save your work as you go—whether that’s using version control tools (for code) or simply saving copies on your computer—so you always have a backup and can iterate more quickly.

Use AI to create leverage, not just output. The real value isn’t just generating text or code—it’s accelerating experimentation and iteration. Use AI to test ideas and create rough versions you can quickly refine.

Just like with generative AI, I don’t have a fixed workflow for this—and I don’t think you need one. Most of the value comes from applying these principles consistently, not following a perfectly defined process.

The tools will keep evolving. What matters is how you approach them.

Your Move: Three Thoughts on What to do Next

1. Embrace it, Don't Fear It

You've probably heard the line: AI won't take your job — but someone who knows how to use it might. By now, it's almost a cliché. But like most clichés, it's stuck around because there's truth in it.

It's increasingly clear that AI will be able to perform large parts of most white-collar jobs in the near future. But it will also unlock entirely new kinds of work that don't yet exist. Just as the internet gave rise to social media, eCommerce, and AI itself, AI will reshape the landscape in ways we can scarcely predict.

The real challenge — and the real opportunity — isn't just asking which jobs will disappear, but what new forms of value, creativity, and collaboration will emerge.

AI won't replace curiosity. It won't replace judgment, taste, or the ability to ask better questions. It won't replace the people bold enough to rethink how work gets done.

It will replace work that's repetitive, unoriginal, and resistant to change—and amplify the people doing what it can't.

The shift isn't from human to machine. It's from manual to augmented. From linear effort to leveraged impact.

2. Rethink What's Possible

Here's what I think is undersold in most conversations about AI: it's not just a faster way to do what you already do.

It changes what's possible, in two powerful ways:

AI democratizes leverage.

In the last chapter, I mentioned how AI tools are making scripting tools like Google Apps Script accessible to people who don't know how to code. Before AI, the tool existed—but the leverage didn't. Now it does.

AI doesn't just speed up existing workflows. It unlocks ones that weren't accessible before—because the skill gap was too steep, the work too tedious, or the effort was too high to justify. The question isn't what you know anymore. The question isn't what you know anymore—it's what you can imagine and how quickly you can turn it into something real.

The people who figure this out early won't just be a little more productive. They'll be operating on a completely different level.

AI compresses the distance between idea and execution.

AI isn't just expanding who can build—it's changing how quickly things can be built.

In the past, having an idea and actually building it were very different things—you needed time, expertise, or a team. AI shrinks that gap. You can prototype faster, test ideas sooner, and build things that once required specialists.

It's no longer just about who has the skills to build. It's about who has the ideas—and the initiative to pursue them.

3. Use the Right AI Tool for the Job

Remember my tool metaphor? The idea that there's a right tool for every job.

The same rule applies to AI.

As these tools mature and multiply, the most productive people won't be the ones who work the hardest. They'll be the ones who choose the right AI tool for the right job—and learn how to use it well.

So don't sit on the sidelines.

Use the tools. Try the modes.

Learn the best prompts for your role or use case. Write them down. Build a prompt library. Share it with your team.

Experiment with collaborative tools to create things you couldn't have made on your own.

And as agentic platforms become reliable enough for your work, start giving them real responsibility—small at first, then bigger.

The people who learn how to delegate to machines early will help define how this next era of work actually gets done. It's not about replacing yourself—it's about using leverage to increase your output, your impact, and the quality of your work.

The future won't belong to those who work the hardest.
It will belong to those who understand leverage.

The tools are already here.

What you build with them is up to you.

The right tool, used well, expands what's possible.

Before you go...

A few more things—practical, personal, and optional.

One last note

In 2019, I left an in-office job at a small marketing agency near where I'm from.

I've been working remotely ever since.

In that time, I've worked on large teams and small teams, at startups and agencies, even as a contractor. Something I've learned along the way is that not all remote teams, and not all knowledge workers, work the same.

Some waste minutes searching for docs and tabs that should take seconds to find. Some struggle with workflows that could be automated. And some lose hours to miscommunication—unclear ownership, vague requests, and constant back-and-forth just to clarify what should have been simple.

Working online doesn't automatically make you productive. In fact, if you don't have the right foundations, it can often make things worse.

That's what inspired me to write this book. If anything, I hope it helps you (and your team) work a little smarter, save time, communicate more clearly, and use tools that genuinely make your life easier—not harder.

Remote work benefits everyone involved—the people doing the work, their families, and even the planet. But it only delivers on that promise when it's done right.

Productivity doesn't come from proximity. It comes from clear systems, smart tools, and accountability that isn't dependent on being in the same room.

This is my attempt to help teams design work around outcomes instead of offices—built around systems that don't just function, but thrive.

So, if you know someone who might benefit from this book—a teammate, a colleague, a friend—send it their way.

It might help more than you think.

About the author

Hi, I'm **Brendan Bockes**—a web strategist, writer, and productivity nerd.

Over the years, I've partnered with startups, agencies, and distributed teams of all sizes, helping them get more done in less time while building websites and web-apps that drive meaningful results.

When I'm not working, I'm usually reading, cooking, or building things—from productivity apps to books like this one—and documenting what I learn along the way.

You can read my blog at blog.brendanbockes.com.

Learn more about my work at brendanbockes.com.

Or connect with me on [LinkedIn](#).

A small request

Congrats! You made it to the end of this book.

If you've got two more minutes, I'd really appreciate your feedback.

Click the link below and fill out the short form. I'll use your response to improve the next edition.

[Leave feedback →](#)

Thanks!

Appendix

Tools and resources.

Keyboard Shortcuts for Windows

[Return to Navigation Shortcuts]

Basics

Copy – Ctrl + C

Paste – Ctrl + V

Undo – Ctrl + Z

Redo – Ctrl + Y

Select All – Ctrl + A

Move to the next field/button in an interface – Tab

Move to the previous field/button in an interface – Shift + Tab

Find (Search in page/document) – Ctrl + F

New (new document/window) – Ctrl + N

Browser navigation

Open a new tab – Ctrl + T

Close tab – Ctrl + W

Switch tabs – Ctrl + Tab

Jump to a specific tab – Ctrl + [number]

Back a page – Alt + ←

Forward a page – Alt + →

Jump to address bar – Ctrl + L

Reopen closed tab – Ctrl + Shift + T

App switching & control

Switch between open apps – Alt + Tab

See all open windows (Task View) – Win + Tab

Close current app – Alt + F4

Window management

Snap window left/right – Win + ← / →

Maximize current window – Win + ↑

Minimize current window – Win + ↓

Show/Hide desktop – Win + D

Snap window to another monitor – Win + Shift + ← / →

Desktop management (handy for multitasking)

Create new virtual desktop – Win + Ctrl + D

Go to the desktop on the left – Win + Ctrl + ←

Go to the desktop on the right – Win + Ctrl + →

Close current desktop – Win + Ctrl + F4

System Controls

Lock your PC – Win + L

Search apps, files, settings – Win (then type)

Keyboard Shortcuts for Mac

Basics

Copy – Command (⌘) + C

Paste – Command (⌘) + V

Undo – Command (⌘) + Z

Redo – Command (⌘) + Shift + Z

Select All – Command (⌘) + A

Move to the next field/button in an interface – Tab

Move to the previous field/button in an interface – Shift + Tab

Find (Search in page/document) – Command (⌘) + F

New (new document/window) – Command (⌘) + N

Browser navigation

Open a new tab – Command (⌘) + T

Close tab – Command (⌘) + W

Switch tabs – Control + Tab

Jump to a specific tab – Command (⌘) + [number]

Back a page – Command (⌘) + [

Forward a page – Command (⌘) +]

Jump to address bar – Command (⌘) + L

Reopen closed tab – Command (⌘) + Shift + T

App switching & control

Switch between open apps – Command (⌘) + Tab

See all open windows (Mission Control) – Control + ↑ (or F3)

Close current app – Command (⌘) + Q

Window management

Snap window left/right – Fn + Control + ← / →

Maximize current window – Option + Click green button in top-left

Minimize current window – Command (⌘) + M

Show/Hide desktop – F11

Move window to another Space – Control + ↑, drag to Space

Desktop management (handy for multitasking)

Create new virtual desktop (Space) – Control + ↑, then click + in top-left

Go to the desktop on the left – Control + ←

Go to the desktop on the right – Control + →

Close current desktop – Control + ↑, then hover over desktop and click X

System Controls

Lock your Mac – Control + Command (⌘) + Q

Search apps, files, settings (Spotlight) – Command (⌘) + Space

Tools Mentioned By Chapter

Chapter 1 —Workflow Optimization

- [Atext](#)
- [Text Blaze](#)
- [Tweek](#)

Chapter 2 — Cognitive Offloading

- [Magnet](#)
- [Rectangle](#)
- [PowerToys \(FancyZones\)](#)
- [Pasteboard](#)
- [Maccy](#)
- [1Password](#)
- [Bitwarden](#)
- [Instapaper](#)
- [Raindrop](#)
- [MyMind](#)
- [Readwise Reader](#)
- [Obsidian](#)
- [Roam](#)

Chapter 3 — Execution Tools

- [FreeConvert](#)
- [CloudConvert](#)
- [Smallpdf](#)
- [123apps](#)
- [TinyPNG](#)
- [SwissTransfer](#)
- [Copyfish](#)
- [TextSniper](#)
- [Imageye](#)
- [Image Extractor](#)
- [Link Grabber](#)
- [WebRename](#)
- [File Juggler](#)
- [Hazel](#)
- [Listary](#)
- [Alfred](#)

Chapter 4 — Virtual Communication

- [SuperWhisper](#)
- [Flow](#)
- [AudioPen](#)
- [Slack](#)

- [Teams](#)
- [Asana](#)
- [Trello](#)
- [Airtable](#)
- [ClickUp](#)
- [Jira](#)
- [Wrike](#)
- [Notion](#)
- [Mintlify](#)
- [Slab](#)
- [Loom](#)
- [Scribe](#)
- [Guidde](#)
- [Otter](#)
- [NotebookLM](#)

Chapter 5 — Visual Communication

- [Jumpshare](#)
- [CleanShot](#)
- [Figma](#)
- [Miro](#)
- [tldraw](#)
- [Marker.io](#)

- [Markup.io](#)

Chapter 6 — Information Orchestration

- [Google Workspace](#)
- [Google Search Operators Guide](#)
- [Chrome Extensions](#)
- [Screen Ruler](#)
- [Google Apps Script](#)

Chapter 7 — Cognitive Automation

- [ChatGPT](#)
- [Claude](#)
- [Midjourney](#)
- [Sora](#)
- [Cursor](#)
- [Manus](#)
- [Gumloop](#)